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Striking The Right Key

A special keyboard and software designed for those suffering from cerebral palsy helps them express their sentiments better

Renuka Rane

Hemant Sachar is visibly excited. He flails his arms and legs to show his eagerness. Every time you glance at him he gives you an endearing, lopsided grin. Sachar (32) has cerebral palsy and is unable to speak.

He has difficulty hearing and cannot use his hands either. The only way he communicates is through his left foot—he has some control in that limb—directing it accordingly to express himself.

Sachar is strapped to his wheelchair at all times to prevent him from falling. We met him at the Happy Hours Centre, an institution dedicated to people affected with cerebral palsy in Bandra, Mumbai.

Coping With Cerebral Palsy

'Cerebral' refers to the brain, and 'palsy' to muscle weakness. 'Cerebral palsy' describes chronic conditions affecting body movement and muscle coordination. It leads to motor impairment resulting from brain damage in young chil-

dren. While it's not a progressive disorder, secondary conditions that can develop include muscle spasticity, impairment of sight, hearing or speech, seizures and mental retardation.

Happy Hours Centre started in 1973, and is part of the Cerebral Palsy Association of India. Ella D'Souza, co-founder and director of Happy Hours says, "The right training and therapy can help improve the communication abilities of those suffering from cerebral palsy."

The Breakthrough

"Hemant Sachar has been with us for a long time now. We could only teach him to recognise images but

not letters, and so we devised a method of teaching him basic communication using pictures," says D'Souza.

She adds, "We worked hard trying to improve his communication skills using images and signs. And in 2001, there was a breakthrough: we realised that Sachar could respond far better to the written word than the spoken. So, I set up a three-level dummy keyboard made of thermocol with chart paper for a screen. Next, I categorised his daily needs and activities under words essential for basic communication such as 'Go', 'Eat', 'Drink', 'Do', 'Who' and 'Feel'," recalls D'Souza.

Learning One Level Up

The staff at Happy Hours trained Sachar to touch the corresponding keys, by holding cut-outs of each

